

tra software. You can look at gnu.org/distros.

Your journey with FSF had some issues in the recent past. Is there anything that you want to share with your audience?

I resigned from the FSF presidency and Board in September 2019. And I rejoined the Board in 2021. And I'm still on the Board, but I'm not the President. The FSF is learning to get along without me as President, which it



eventually has to do.

It's well known that people started spreading lots of accusations against me, which were mostly false or based on partial truth. I'm not perfect, but I didn't do anything really horrible. But some people pointed out little things about what I say and do and turn them into something horrible. And if you want to read about this, you can look at the Stallman support network which refutes lots of falsehoods.

What do you think FSF India needs to learn from the US or the global counterpart in terms of implementation?

FSF India is not very active. It started as a separate organisation in the early 2000s, but it never really started functioning effectively. At this point, I think it'd be necessary to find a new set of activists who want to carry it forward. Some activists in it are still active in the free software community but FSF India as such is not doing anything.



What are the goals that you would want FSF India to have?

Teach people about free software at the practical level and at the level of ethical philosophy. Convey why it's very important, not merely as a matter of convenience, but as to what is at stake here.

And what is really at stake here?

Freedom is at stake here. Fundamentally, it starts with the freedom to control the software that does your computing. If you let your computing be done by somebody's online service, neither do you control what's running that service nor can you have a way to control it.

How to take that computing into our own hands?

If you want to use Google Docs, there's software on the server that has to be there. And obviously, Google can't let you change that software. Because different people might want different changes, and that doesn't make sense.

But if each of us is free and each of us has the source code, the programmers among us

who want the same changes as we want, can get together and make a change.

It's up to you which version you're going to install and use. This is why free software means you can get what you want. And it's under your control. Otherwise, the software is under the control of somebody else, who is probably looking for an opportunity to mistreat you with it.

Looking at gnu.org/malware, you'll see how many different ways they mistreat people with it.

They design non-free programs to restrict people (digital restrictions management). They make people give personal data in order to keep using it. There are famous online dis-services which swindle people and get them addicted. And partly that's the fault of the server code. But the client code is also involved. If the client code were free software, you could change it and overcome some of the addictive aspects.

So, software freedom, in the direct sense, is freedom in one area of your life. But the more software and computing become involved in other areas of your life, the more software freedom becomes essential to freedom in those areas. **EFY**